

Employee Handbook 2026

Northwind Freight Group — People Policy Manual

1 About This Handbook

This handbook describes the terms, benefits, and expectations that apply to all Northwind Freight Group employees. It is not a contract of employment; your individual contract and any collective agreement take precedence where they differ.

Where this handbook is silent, ask your manager or the People team rather than assuming. Local statutory entitlements always apply in addition to what is written here.

2 Employment Basics

Northwind hires into defined roles with published grade bands. Role changes are made through the internal move process rather than informal reassignment.

2.1 Probation Period

New employees serve a six-month probation period, reduced to three months for internal transfers. During probation either party may end the employment with two weeks' notice. Probation is confirmed in writing; it does not lapse into confirmation automatically.

2.2 Working Hours and Shift Patterns

The standard working week is forty hours. Terminal and dispatch roles operate rotating shifts published four weeks in advance. A published shift may be changed with less than seven days' notice only by agreement with the employee.

Employees working a night shift, defined as any shift with more than three hours falling between 23:00 and 06:00, receive the night shift allowance described in Section 3.3.

2.3 Remote and Hybrid Work

Office-based roles may work remotely up to three days per week with manager agreement. Terminal, dispatch, and driver roles are on-site by nature and are not eligible for hybrid work.

Remote work outside your country of employment requires prior People team approval and is limited to twenty working days per calendar year, because of tax and social security consequences.

3 Compensation and Payroll

Salaries are reviewed annually with effect from 1 April. Reviews consider role band, performance, and market position.

3.1 Pay Cycle

Salaries are paid monthly on the 25th, or the last working day before the 25th where that date falls on a weekend or public holiday. Payslips are available in the employee portal two working days before payment.

Payroll corrections are made in the next available cycle. An underpayment of more than ten per cent of net pay is corrected by off-cycle payment within five working days of being confirmed.

3.2 Overtime

Overtime is worked only when authorised in advance by a manager. Authorised overtime is paid at 1.5 times base hourly rate on weekdays and Saturdays, and at 2.0 times base hourly rate on Sundays and public holidays.

Employees in grade band 6 and above are not eligible for overtime payment and instead take time off in lieu, agreed with their manager and taken within three months.

3.3 Shift and On-Call Allowances

The night shift allowance is twenty per cent of base hourly rate for qualifying hours. On-call duty outside working hours attracts a flat weekly on-call allowance, plus overtime for any hours actually worked while on call.

On-call rotas are published two weeks in advance. An employee may not be rostered on call for more than one week in four without their agreement.

4 Benefits

Benefits begin on the first day of employment unless stated otherwise. Coverage levels are reviewed annually and confirmed in the benefits summary issued each January.

4.1 Medical Cover

All employees are enrolled in the company medical plan from their start date. The plan covers primary consultations, specialist referrals, and hospital treatment within the plan network. Out-of-network treatment is reimbursed at seventy per cent of the in-network rate.

Dependants may be added within thirty days of your start date, or within thirty days of a qualifying life event such as marriage or the birth of a child. Outside those windows, additions wait for the annual enrolment window in November.

4.2 Dental Cover

Dental cover is included in the company medical plan at no additional employee contribution. Preventive treatment, defined as two check-ups and one hygienist visit per calendar year, is covered in full with no co-pay.

Restorative treatment carries a twenty per cent co-pay, capped at one hundred and fifty euro per treatment episode and at six hundred euro per employee per calendar year. Orthodontic treatment carries a fifty per cent co-pay with a lifetime cap of two thousand euro, and is available to employees and enrolled dependants after twelve months of continuous plan membership.

Cosmetic dentistry is excluded from the plan entirely. Pre-authorisation is required for any single course of treatment expected to exceed eight hundred euro.

4.3 Vision Cover

The plan reimburses one eye examination per calendar year in full, and contributes up to two hundred euro every two years towards prescription glasses or lenses. Employees who use display screens for more than four hours a day may claim a screen-use examination annually, separate from the standard entitlement.

4.4 Pension

Northwind contributes six per cent of base salary to the company pension from the start date, rising to eight per cent after five years of service. Employee contributions are voluntary and are matched up to a further two per cent.

Contribution changes take effect from the following pay cycle and may be made twice per calendar year without restriction.

5 Leave and Absence

Leave is tracked in the employee portal. Verbal approval is not a record; leave must be entered and approved in the system before it is taken.

5.1 Annual Leave

Full-time employees receive twenty-five days of annual leave per calendar year, accrued monthly. Employees with more than five years of service receive twenty-eight days.

Up to five unused days may be carried into the following year and must be taken by 31 March. Days beyond five are forfeited unless carry-over was blocked by an operational refusal, in which case the full balance carries.

5.2 Sickness Absence

Report sickness absence to your manager before your shift start, or within one hour of it where that is not possible. Self-certification covers the first seven calendar days; absence beyond seven days requires a medical certificate.

Company sick pay is full pay for the first twenty working days of absence in any rolling twelve-month period, then statutory pay thereafter. A return-to-work conversation is held after any absence of more than five working days.

5.3 Parental Leave

Parental leave follows the statutory entitlement of your country of employment, topped up by Northwind to full pay for the first sixteen weeks. The top-up applies to both parents and is not reduced if both parents work for Northwind.

Notice of intended parental leave is required at least eight weeks before the planned start. Return to the same role is guaranteed for absences of up to twelve months.

5.4 Unpaid and Special Leave

Unpaid leave of up to three months may be granted at the manager's discretion after two years of service. Bereavement leave is five paid days for an immediate family member and two paid days otherwise. Two paid days per year are available for civic duties such as jury service where these are not separately compensated.

6 Travel and Expenses

Business travel is booked through the corporate travel tool. Bookings made outside the tool are reimbursed only where the tool was unavailable and the exception is documented.

6.1 Booking and Class of Travel

Flights under six hours are booked in economy class. Flights over six hours may be booked in premium economy with director approval. Rail travel is booked in standard class, or first class where the fare is lower than the standard flexible fare for the same journey.

Hotels are booked within the published city caps. Where no room is available inside the cap, book the nearest available option and note the reason in the expense claim.

6.2 Per Diem and Meals

A per diem covers meals and incidental costs and is paid at the published country rate. Where a meal is provided by the company or a host, the per diem is reduced by the corresponding meal fraction: twenty per cent for breakfast, thirty per cent for lunch, and fifty per cent for dinner.

Alcohol is not reimbursable except at a client-facing event approved in advance by a director.

6.3 Claim Deadlines

Expense claims must be submitted within thirty days of the expense being incurred, with receipts attached for any item above twenty-five euro. Claims submitted after sixty days are paid only with finance director approval.

Approved claims are reimbursed in the next payroll cycle. Reimbursement is never made in cash.

7 Conduct and Acceptable Use

Northwind expects honest, safe, and respectful behaviour from everyone, at every site, and in every interaction with customers and carrier partners.

7.1 Standards of Conduct

Harassment, discrimination, and retaliation are prohibited and are treated as gross misconduct. Concerns may be raised with any manager, the People team, or the confidential reporting line, and may be raised anonymously.

Safety-critical roles are subject to a zero-tolerance standard on alcohol and drugs during working hours and while on call.

7.2 Information and IT Acceptable Use

Company systems are provided for business use. Limited personal use is acceptable where it does not interfere with work or breach any other policy. Customer data may not be copied to personal devices or personal cloud accounts under any circumstances.

Report a suspected security incident, including a lost device or a suspicious message, to the IT service desk immediately. Reporting promptly is never itself a disciplinary matter.

Appendix — Who to Contact

People team for pay, benefits, and leave questions. Payroll for payslip and tax code corrections. IT service desk for access and security incidents. Confidential reporting line for conduct concerns. Contact details are published on the intranet contacts page and reviewed monthly.